

Hope Floats

Healthcare reaches the poorest of the poor in the far-flung riverine islands of the Brahmaputra

Arunachal Pradesh

ASSAM

Dibrugarh

BRAHMAPUTRA



ABHJIT DASGUPTA

VILLAGERS POSE WITH THE FLOATING HOSPITAL

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

This is one hospital with a difference: Patients don't go to it; it floats to them. The many inaccessible islands in the Brahmaputra river now have a common connecting link—hospital boats from the award-winning project, Ships of Hope—that brings them quality medical care right at their doorstep. Former journalist Sanjoy Hazarika who was moved by the plight of the Brahmaputra's island dwellers when he made a film, *The River Story: Quest for the Brahmaputra* in 2000, initiated the unique project. "I realised there were many human interest stories, but there was a much bigger humanitarian problem. I once heard a story about a Mishing tribeswoman who died of miscarriage because she could not find a boat to ferry her to a town hospital." Such stories propelled Hazarika to launch the project at Dibrugarh with support from the National Rural Health Mission (NRHM), the state Government and Unicef.

Ships of Hope now has 10 boats with doctors, nurses and other employees, covering more than two lakh villagers and 465 islands along the mighty river. The

boats, designed by Hazarika with local help, keeping the fluctuating currents of the river in mind, have almost everything that a hospital can ask for—doctors' chambers, operation theatres, pharmacies and rooms for doctors to stay. "It is a difficult job for those on duty. So we decided to provide accommodation to the doctors," says Hazarika.

The health clinic story that began with a single boat called *Akha* (hope in Assamese) in Dibrugarh district in 2005 now reaches some of the most backward areas in Assam called chars. Families with children spend their days on the fields and are prey to floods. Often, people lose their homes and livestock in the floods. Mission Director, NRHM, Government of Assam, J.B. Ekka, says: "The boat clinic initiative has helped in delivering healthcare to isolated communities, especially through immunisation of women and children." The project that got a World Bank award in 2004 for transforming the lives of rural communities now plans to take healthcare to 10 lakh persons, or one-third of the flood-vulnerable population of the state, by 2011.